

Understanding customer experience of culinary tourism through food tours of Delhi

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Abstract

Purpose – This paper attempts to identify emerging themes that focus on customer experience of culinary tourism of international tourists who opted for food tours in Delhi.

Design/methodology/approach – The paper uses a multi-method approach for data collection. A thorough review of literature was conducted followed by gaining insights from the industry experts for the themes and a tentative thematic table was established. Thereafter, secondary data comprising 1,744 customer reviews from world's leading travel website – Tripadvisor.com was analysed using thematic analysis. Customer's real-time feedback and industry insights were paired together to gather meaningful and practical insights on customer experiences of food tours in Delhi.

Findings – Culinary tourism of Delhi is facing challenge in the areas of infrastructure, hygiene and certain preconceived notions related to brand perception of Indian cuisines. The findings of the study allude that the food tour agencies must be professional with all certifications and attention must be paid to location of food tastings, as it become the representation of Indian food worldwide. The findings also indicate customization is the key to positive customer experience, thereby requiring culinary professionals to understand the customer choices and personalize the food tours accordingly. Online reputation management is another key area requiring attention as electronic word of mouth plays a major role in the hospitality industry.

Research limitations/implications – Although this study corroborates valuable academic findings and practical insights, it has few limitations that can be further investigated in the future. A quantitative study can be conducted to provide deeper insights into the factors of a culinary tour resulting in positive customer experience. Secondly, this study focuses on customer experience of food tours which is one of the forms of Culinary tourism, another elaborate study can be conducted incorporating other methods of culinary tourism such as cooking classes, food festivals, events etc. and delving into insights of customer experience and challenges in those practices.

Practical implications – Themes ascertained in this research paper provide deeper and worthy insights to all the stakeholders which would help them use their tourism resources in best optimal manner. Findings of the study would be valuable to culinary organizations, tourism department and other researchers working in the area of culinary tourism. Also, this study can be quite valuable for the academic researchers. Suggestions of the study will help the government, culinary organizations and other stakeholders to enhance culinary tourist experiences of Delhi.

Originality/value – The study is original and highly appropriate to all the stakeholders to formulate suitable strategic framework to improve customer experience in the field of culinary tourism. Using real customer experiences as data and choosing thematic analysis as a method of analysis further enhance the worth of study by opening the area for further exploration.

Keywords Customization, e-WOM, Thematic analysis, Culinary tourism, Customer experience

Paper type Research paper

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Introduction

The experience economy is on an upsurge as customers are no longer looking for basic need attainment but a fulfilled experience (Pine and Gilmore, 1999).

Food has the power to influence the likeability and destination attachment. Therefore, it becomes peremptory of the travel and food industry to enhance their products into higher value experiences (Henderson, 2009). This impeccable opportunity and tourists' commitment towards food has led to food-based tourism also known as culinary tourism which involves an array of activities like sampling, discovering local food and its ingredients (Wolf, 2002). Culinary tourism is almost the direct link towards the local culture, landscape, food/wine, history and creating an atmosphere towards a memorable travel experience (Hjalager and Richards, 2002). The global culinary tourism market size is expected to grow by US\$82bn with a compound annual growth rate of over 9% during the period 2019–2023 (Technavio, 2019). India's tourism sector is expected to reach over US\$500bn by 2029 (Statista, 2019).

Culinary tourism, as suggested by Long (2004) is to express the idea of tourists' experiencing other cultures via food. IGI Global (2017) explicate any tourism activity which involves paying visit to restaurants and tasting and having food at a destination of interest is food tourism. Tourism related to food is often termed as food tourism, culinary tourism or gastronomy tourism (Ab Karim and Chi, 2010). The World food travel association defines culinary tourism as pursuit and enjoyment of unique and memorable food and drink experiences. A culinary traveller wishes to experience the local culture via authentic dishes, recipes of the native place (Sohn and Yuan, 2013).

As per Shenoy (2005), tourist's activities such as dining, buying food products, visits to food producing and experiencing anything related to food comes under food tourism. Activities such as visiting primary and secondary food producers, culinary fairs, farmer's marketplace, attending cooking classes, tasting food quality, fruits/vegetables or spice festivals classify as culinary tourism (Hall and Sharples, 2003). These tours are generally conducted in groups and private both with usual duration varying between a few hours to one week. Beer *et al.* (2012) argue culinary tourists prefer typical local dishes at a lower price range in non-fine dining rather rustic ambience. Hence, culinary tourism should not be considered as a niche product but as a complete and satisfying experience led by cultural heritage (Ignatov and Smith, 2006).

Various countries such as Italy, Thailand, France and Japan have been capitalizing on their cuisines in the world of gastronomy tourism. India despite of a variety of dishes, flavours and rich heritage has not been able to make a mark in this domain. Bilro *et al.* (2018) infer positive customer experience can lead to customer delight, build brand loyalty and brand advocacy. This brand advocacy, along with the customer reviews form the basis of user generated content (UGC) which plays a decisive role for destination planning (Sashi, 2012). The primary objective of this research is to find what are the customer experiences of international tourists opting for culinary tours in Delhi. What factors of a culinary tour lead to a positive customer experience and what are the respective areas of improvement of food tours being conducted in Delhi.

Customer experience

Customer experience is described as a set of interactions between a customer and any part of an organization (Verhoef *et al.*, 2009). Customers interact with the organization via diverse touchpoints resulting in complex customer journeys and emotions. Lemke *et al.* (2010) defines customer experience as the holistic encounter of the customer with the firm, it may include direct or indirect encounters, for example communication, service or consumption encounter. Schmitt (1999) considers customer experience as multidimensional in nature and identifies five types of experiences: sensory (sense), affective (feel), cognitive (think), physical (act) and social-identity (relate) experiences. Brakus *et al.* (2009) conceptualize brand experience as subjective and influenced by customer responses such as feelings, cognitions and behavioural responses provoked by brand. As per Klaus and Maklan (2013), Customer experience is the sum of all direct indirect interactions with the service provider which helps identify priority areas for managerial attention. The dimension peace-of-mind

and moments-of-truth has the greatest influence on customer satisfaction and word-of-mouth behavior (Klaus and Maklan, 2013). A positive customer experience promotes emotional relationship between the brand and the customer which in turn enhances brand loyalty (Gentile *et al.*, 2007).

Fatma (2014) highlights the importance of moments of truth a customer comes across during pre-experience and post experience study to find out the factors which shape customer experience namely brand experience, multichannel interactions, service interface, physical environment, social environment and price and promotions. The firms need to ensure positive customer experience so the customer builds brand loyalty, leave positive word of mouth, evangelize the product which will help in new customer acquisition and retaining old customers via the built loyalty. Culinary tourists' motivation is positively associated with culinary experience and satisfaction; and that the culinary tourist experience is positively associated with both culinary tourist satisfaction and loyalty (Agyeiwaah *et al.*, 2018).

Delhi as a culinary destination

Delhi is a quite dynamic city and popular for its diverse cuisines. The food ranges from authentic to modern and fusion cuisines.

The cuisines of Delhi makes one discover all distinctive tastes and has a wide variety of pickles, curries, masalas (spices) which carry the power to alter the level of spices thereby complimenting the taste of the cuisines. The rationale behind choosing Delhi as subject of culinary tours research is that it offers food connoisseurs an unparalleled sojourn of tastes which is inspired by various eras such as Mughal, Portuguese. Delhi food tours make the tourist experience the heritage and the era while providing delectable tastes in the dishes by offering food tours, food tasting tours, photography walks, city walks, spices market visit and cooking classes.

Delhi food walks are majorly run in Old Delhi, Chandni Chowk and Chawri Bazar which has heritage and lifestyle of its own. Chandni Chowk is situated in the heart of Old Delhi where the city's heritage has been preserved owing to a completely immersive experience. Chandni Chowk is a busy shopping area having fabric market, silver jewellery market, spices market, dried fruits, and all kinds of traditional sweets. Restaurants are multi-generational business with vintage more than 150 years backed up by cultures and rich heritage. Selection of culinary places should reflect what "real" the destination has to offer and what customers will find exotic (Long, 2018). Food reflects how societies and cultures got their respective structure in that country/region (Park *et al.*, 2019). Hence, a lot of deliberation should go into what cuisines should be a part of culinary tours.

Research should begin with a research question and the analysis should answer those research questions over the course of the data analysis process (Castleberry and Nolen, 2018). This leads us to the below mentioned research questions:

- RQ1. What are the customer experiences of international tourists who opted for culinary tours in Delhi?
- RQ2. What factors of a culinary tour result in positive customer experience?
- RQ3. What are the improvement areas to enhance the customer experience of culinary food tours of Delhi?

Literature review

Literature should be given utmost importance to facilitate literary interpretation, as worthy content is borrowed from literature only and this serves as a basis of novel concepts (Nathan, 2013).

Food needs to be exotic enough to arouse a curiosity to taste and learn about the recipes of the same. Food adds to the emotions by reflecting the cultural patterns of a region. Tourists consider necessities such as amenities, food and water and proper infrastructural facilities such as accommodation, transport, accessibility indispensable. [Banerjee \(2015\)](#). Food communities and trends in lifestyle have also resulted in latest forms of gastronomic experiences, Culinary tourists use their travel experiences to accentuate their distinctive knowledge of specific cuisines, foods or preparation methods ([Richards, 2015](#)). However, prior research substantiates the belief that most tourists focus on the authenticity of the dishes as eating local cuisines strikes an empathy in a traveller's mind, as well as in the host's mind, as it creates a feeling that the tourist "cares" ([Everett and Aitchison, 2008](#); [Ellis et al., 2018](#)). The quality of ingredients and the freshness of meal affects the culinary experiences of a destination ([Chuang, 2009](#); [Kivela and Crofts, 2006](#)). Fresh food is an absolute charm for a culinary tourist. Quality and freshness of food encourages the tourists to try authentic cuisines ([Hendijani, 2016](#); [Kim et al., 2010](#)). [OECD \(2012\)](#) discusses the consistency in food quality is an additional dimension of the customer experience.

Usually tourists use internet and Social Media for culling a destination and planning their travel. Significant developments have imbued media with the power of controlling a traveller's preferences. The use of Internet and Social Media have a direct influence on tourism promotion ([UNWTO Report, 2017](#)) Sources includes various websites and platforms where customers share their experiences in many ways, ranging from posting their stories, feedbacks, comments with pictures and videos, blogging, collaborative tagging, community posting which helps the customer in deciding on the same location. Also, it beholds the power to make a tourist choose their travel destination and the kind of activities they would want to experience. ([Xiang and Gretzel, 2010](#)).

[Brochado and Rita \(2018\)](#) and [Moshin and Ryan \(2003\)](#) corroborates informal communication, i.e. UGC in the form of electronic word of mouth is quite significant for those who consider customers' reviews reliable. Therefore, online reputation management has become vital with the growth of UGC in the hospitality and tourism industry. Reputation management refer to the efforts made by business to interact with customer's negative comments about products and management ([Noort and Willemsen, 2012](#)). Most UGC websites such as TripAdvisor provide a space for business to interact and respond to both positive and negative reviews ([Filiari, 2016](#)). Also, if reviews are detailed and well explained backed up by logics, they positively influence likelihood of purchase ([Park et al., 2007](#)). However, responding in the case of negative reviews becomes even more crucial ([Lui et al., 2018](#)). In addition, potential customers are more likely to be influenced by negative reviews than positive ones ([Chevalier and Mayzlin, 2006](#)). As a result, online reputation management is associated more strongly with online complaints than compliments ([Noort and Willemsen, 2012](#)).

Tourists trends reveal that customization leads to highly fragmented demand ([Hjalager and Richards, 2011](#)). A number of authors posit that personalized services raise customers' levels of interaction and, ultimately, increase customer loyalty and satisfaction and enhanced customer experience ([McMillan and Hwang, 2002](#); [Rust and Chung, 2006](#)). Furthermore, the organization may gain competitive advantage ([Murthi and Sarkar, 2003](#)) and may raise its profitability ([Zhang and Wedel, 2009](#)). Also, specific dietary and personal preferences for food is also a subject of matter which makes customization more indispensable ([OECD, 2012](#)). The attributes contributing to the culinary tourism experience included: learning and knowledge, food quality, food variety, service quality and senses beyond taste, local culture, fun entertainment. Moreover, sustainability and Social Media/ technology also, contributes to great culinary tourism experiences ([Minihan, 2014](#)). "Quality of the dishes", "variety of the dishes", "prices", "facilities", "environment of establishments", "innovation and new flavours in the dishes" are few factors which contribute to gastronomic experiences ([Nicoletti et al., 2019](#)). [Sanchez-Cañizares and Castillo-Canalejo \(2015\)](#)

outlines price to be a major contributing factor while choosing culinary tourism for a destination. Experiential attempts into service, fellow travellers and settings are also major contributors to the most memorable experiences (Stone *et al.*, 2017).

Safety and health concerns are contributors of food neophobia (MacNicol *et al.*, 2003). Tourists' have apprehensions about safety and hygiene standards about the local food which creates a significant barrier to experience new cuisine. The authenticity of dishes in such undertaking was found to be a concern for culinary experiences (Cohen and Avieli, 2004). Further, tourists' hesitation about cleanliness and wholesomeness (Kim *et al.*, 2010) and safety issues (Chang, 2017) make them sceptical about local foods and their preparation styles. Tourists entail several needs and expectations which are a result of cultural backgrounds, intellect and passions and interests, Therefore, a competent and trained guide would educate the tourists in terms of table manners, local eating habits, local body language and much more (Chang, 2012; Batra, 2008).

Boswijk *et al.* (2005) asserts tourists should be equipped with standardized physical facilities and tools to empower them to carve their own personal experience. Also, storytelling becomes an important means to link food to the history and civilization of that country. Training is important for not only chefs but across the value chain of gastronomy tourism (Caber *et al.*, 2018; Weiler and Ham, 2002). While conducting a tour and educating the foreign tourists about the local food, workforce must be equipped with all relevant skills entailing food research, language, demographics, consumer behavior and techniques. Training of young professionals in the field of culinary tourism should be supported by the Government with an aim to ensure quality standards in service (UNWTO Report, 2017). Caber *et al.* (2018) and K ro lu (2014) pointed out tour guides are the people who transform tours into experiences and enhance tourist satisfaction and repeat purchase of the tours.

The literature review revealed that only limited research has been conducted in this domain. There is also minimal interaction between academic discourses, tourist agencies, digital travel domains, culinary tourism marketeers. Deeper commitment to food studies can help understand cultures and human activities better (Neuman, 2018) Table 1 represents tentative themes which occur from Literature and prior research.

Methodology

This study uses a mixed method approach and is qualitative in nature. Exploratory research design has been used for the study. Literature review was conducted, themes were explored and tentative themes were developed. To study the industry perspective, insights

Table 1 Tentative thematic table from prior research

<i>Sr. no.</i>	<i>Tentative broad themes</i>	<i>Tentative sub-themes</i>
1	Food	Quality Quantity Authenticity of the food Variety
2	Hygiene and Cleanliness	
3	Tour Guide	Training and Certifications Professional Storyteller Informative
4	Digital Presence	Online reputation management Pre and post communication
5	Customization	
6	Price of the tour	
7	Facilities	Infrastructure

were collected from tour founders, tour operators via personal interviews. Qualitative methods such as personal interviews help to obtain deeper understanding in comparison to quantitative methods such as questionnaires (Berg, 2009). Thereafter, online freely accessible secondary data was explicated from Tripadvisor.com in the form of customer reviews using thematic analysis. Thematic analysis has been chosen for analysis as it is a quite useful method of drawing insights from real events and experiences (Nowell *et al.*, 2017). Thematic analysis help discover the themes that are salient in text, thematic network help structuring and depicting these themes, the process from text to theme chart is well established in qualitative data (Attride-Stirling, 2001). Thematic analysis helps organize data in a better manner and help identify and establish themes which can be represented in thematic web or thematic table (Clarke and Braun, 2016).

Data collection

Data has been gathered using primary, as well as secondary sources, data reliability and validity is quite important in data triangulation. With an aim to increase the validity, distinct data sources were used enabling data triangulation (Guion *et al.*, 2011). Hence, the data sources for this study were from two different stake holders- culinary tour founders/operators and customers. Six personal interviews were undertaken with the tour founders and tour operators (Table 2). These interviews were conducted with the aim to verify themes which came from reviewing the literature could be encompassed to Indian scenario. Themes identified in one setting were valid and transferable in the other setting.

TripAdvisor is the largest “social travel website” in the world, with an overwhelming presence in virtual travel planning discoursing 390 million average monthly visitors in 49 markets worldwide. TripAdvisor has high trust factor as the platform offers advises and feedbacks from millions of real travellers (UNWTO Report, 2017). Hence, to understand the customer experiences of culinary tourism though food walks, TripAdvisor was considered to be the source for secondary data.

Sampling method

Food tours were searched on TripAdvisor website, under the “Things to do in New Delhi” tab, further under “Food & Drink” Tab, top 3 food tours were picked through sorting based on “Traveler ranked”. TripAdvisor’s three food & drink tours which had highest number of reviews implying this tour had been taken more often and more feedbacks would provide more data and hence, would lead to better results. In totality these three food & drink tours had 1,744 reviews, the breakup of these reviews is mentioned in Table 3. Six industry experts from these three food tours were chosen through purposive sampling to conduct personal interviews. Experts were chosen carefully through purposive sampling based on their years of experience and accomplishments and their “unique ability to shed light on the phenomenon” (Creswell, 2013). Interviews were ceased after the sixth interview as data saturation was approached (Dworkin, 2012).

Table 2 Sample for Phase 1 of the study i.e. personal interviews

<i>Interviewee</i>	<i>Years of experience</i>	<i>Designation</i>	<i>Food tours</i>
I	9	Founder	A
II	9	Founder	B
III	8	Co- founder and Senior Tour Operator	A
IV	7	Senior Tour Operator	B
V	11	Founder	C
VI	3	Tour Operator	A

Table 3 Sample for Phase 2 of the study i.e. thematic analysis of customer reviews

<i>S.no.</i>	<i>Food tour</i>	<i>Food Tour name</i>	<i>Reviews on trip advisor</i>	<i>Traveler rating</i>
1	B	Delhi food walks	701	Excellent 658 Very Good 38 Average 3 Poor 2 Terrible 0
2	A	Food tour in Delhi	651	Excellent 617 Very Good 26 Average 6 Poor 2 Terrible 0
3	C	Delhi by locals	392	Excellent 388 Very Good 4 Average 0 Poor 0 Terrible 0

Sample description

Phase 1 sample has been presented in Table 2 and Phase 2 sample in Table 3. Tour founders and tour operators were interviewed to understand the factors contributing to a successful food tour and the challenges faced by the industry. For the same food tours, 1,744 reviews were deeply studied which rated the tours as “Excellent” means customers were quite satisfied with the tour to customer ratings as “terrible” which expresses high level of dissatisfaction. All 1,744 reviews on TripAdvisor were of international tourists as there were only international tourists’ reviews available on the platform. International tourists hailed from countries such as South Africa, Hong Kong, UK, USA, Ireland, Australia, Mexico OR, Canada, Brazil, Oman, Israel, Norway, France, Myanmar and many more. Reviews were considered of past 6 years, i.e. from 2013 to September 2019 to understand if there have been any amendments in styles of conducting the tour or expectations of the culinary customer. Upon seeking clarification on why reviews from only international tourists are available on TripAdvisor, tour managers mentioned “mostly foreigners take this tour as for the native residents know where to eat and what to eat”. Reviews were available from all kinds of tourist’s type including solo travellers, travellers with friends and family.

Research procedure

The research was conducted in two phases:

1. Phase 1: Personal interviews of the culinary tour founders/tour operators consisting of 12 open ended questions focusing on India as a culinary destination, practices offered by Delhi food tours, where does Indian culinary tours lack, prerequisites of running a food tour and what components provide a positive customer experience
2. Phase 2: Customer feedback was explored from TripAdvisor.com to have an actual insight into the real customer experiences who opted for the food tour in Delhi.

For the same food tours, 1,744 reviews were deeply studied which rated the tours as “Excellent”, “Very good”, “Average”, “Poor” and “Terrible”. All of these reviews were taken into consideration while studying customer reviews as positive reviews signified themes underlying positive customer experience while the negative feedback allowed to explore the areas of improvement to enhance customer experience.

Unfortunately, data do not “speak for themselves” (Yin, 2011). Hence, principles of Boyatzis (1998) were followed for the study and a hybrid approach which allowed both deductive

and inductive analysis of themes, was adopted in Phase 1 and Phase 2 of this study. Based on the Literature, “a priori” coding manual was developed based on template approach (Crabtree and Miller, 1999). Themes extracted from the literature review adds depth to the current studies. Data was analysed into themes and sub themes using axial coding. Braun and Clarke (2006) describe a theme represents patterned meaning within the data and a sub theme represents hierarchy of meaning within the data. For current study, theme is said to be a cluster of experiences. The research instrument for personal interviews with open ended questions was designed using the same coding manual. Interview transcripts were read repeatedly to formulate codes and codes were re-examined by re reading. Data interpretation of personal interview was conducted based on Crewell methods (2007).

For the consumer data analysis from reviews, coding was conducted with research objective in mind and themes were identified with respect to pre-existing codes extracted from literature. A code manual includes detailed definitions and text, a coding framework provides a clear trail of evidence for the trustworthiness of the research are significant components of thematic analysis (Nowell *et al.*, 2017; Crabtree and Miller, 1999). Natural occurring themes from the data were drawn out and newly transpiring themes were identified and evolved. Data should not be abandoned, themes should be combined, separated or discarded such that the data within themes should league meaningfully, with a clear and identifiable distinction (Rishi and Joshi, 2016). Therefore, the themes which did not fit our context of culinary tourism experiences were rejected and not considered for the final themes. Data analysis, categorization and sub categorization of data into themes and the relationship establishment between themes and sub themes was conducted parallelly (Saldana, 2009). Based on the coding manual and initial codes, themes and sub themes were identified from the customer reviews data. Relationship among themes was identified using the logics of contrasts and comparisons. The final analysis should narrate the tale about themes and the topic (Braun and Clarke, 2006). Further, for reliability, literature was consulted by both the authors, coding was done individually, and the initial notes were consulted. Upon discussion, results were found to be similar and hence, coding manual was prepared. The initial thematic table was validated using results of axial coding technique. Finally, comprehensive themes were added to develop the final thematic table i.e. Table 4. The Table illustrates the manager’s insights from the industry along with the culinary tourist’s real time experiences.

Findings and discussions

Industry perspective

Personal interviews from tour founders and managers direct Delhi has not fully capitalized on its real cuisine, history, and culture. Following are the discussions which happened during the interviews.

Interviewee I recommended one should indulge in a food tour as he/she arrives at the destination to develop his likes about food he would like to continue in the rest of his trip. Further, he describes Indian food is a cultural saga and how Mughals and British rule have impacted the Delhi food. “Food tours and food tasting tours are two different activities, food tasting tours are associated just with tasting and sampling of food whereas food tours are a broader concept wherein there is a cultural aspect associated with it, [...] storytelling, history behind the food is explained on sojourn”, he explains.

Their food tours are experiencing customer’s inquisitiveness towards cooking classes, and a tourist’s desire to be equipped with in depth knowledge of Indian spices, ingredients cooking techniques. Their organization ensures food operators have all the required certifications and do a 6 month on the job training before they handle the tours solely. Other significant characteristics include customization and story curation with respect to tourist profiles. “An early and detailed customer profiling tells us about their food choices and food

Table 4 Validated themes of customer experiences of culinary tourism through the food tours of delhi

Sr. no.	Tentative broad themes	Tentative sub-themes
1	Food	Quality Quantity Authenticity Variety
2	Hygiene and cleanliness	
3	Tour guide	Training and Certifications Professional Storyteller Informative <i>Language expert</i>
4	<i>Location of food tastings</i>	
5	Digital presence	Online reputation management Pre and post communication
6	Customization	Special requests <i>Food preferences</i> <i>Food allergies</i> <i>Pick and drop facilities</i>
7	Price of the tour	
8	Infrastructure and Facilities	<i>Modes of travel</i> Infrastructure <i>Philanthropic activities</i>
9	<i>Brand perception of Indian culinary industry</i>	

Note: Themes mentioned in italics have emerged from the consumers' review and personal interviews data

allergies help us design the tour better [...] so that we can carve the customer journey in a better way", he explains. Major challenge which they come across is "the mindset of foreign tourist that Indian food will give them Diarrhea, stomach related problems, so, rebuilding the image of the Delhi culinary tourism is of great priority".

The organization is engaged in practices such as giving free gloves and caps to the cooks at food joints as a part of giving back to the society/work, he is into.

Interviewee II revealed that Delhi food carries vintage and a rich history and how the food has evolved over time. So, all ingredients and aromas have a rich cultural heritage, "We must bank upon the same to gain popularity in culinary tourism industry. [...] Locations of food tastings should be chosen wisely [...] and it depends on a number of factors like hygiene, ingredient quality, freshness of the food prepared, diversity and the vintage of the eating joint". Also, he mentioned "Tour guide can make a boring journey/tour very interesting; He can work as a catalyst [...] He must carry a number of qualities in himself and also be personable to the tourists, [...] The USP of my tour is the storytelling and understanding the tourist's taste and delivering the experiences accordingly":

"Online Blogging and shows like Chef's table, Streetfood Asia, various YouTubers are the reason of increasing culinary tourism of India [...] Infrastructure is a huge challenge he faces in Chandni Chowk, Chawri Bazar which are culinary tourist's paradise".

Interviewee III stated that "Culinary tours started late in India [...] so, there is a lot of untapped potential as most tourists are inspired by soft powers of India like Yog, History and wildlife". He further mentions, "Food safety, authentic flavors, educative value, Immersion into local culture are the essential characteristics of a good food tour".

Major ways to explore culinary tourism of a country are food tours, cooking classes, wine tasting, tea tasting, farm tours and bar crawls.

In his opinion, “Delhi has the best and most varied food in India. Many places like Old Delhi has food shops which are recognized well almost all over the country [...] It is also much more open to new influences and ideas than many other tourist destinations. Then there are other factors like comparatively better infrastructure, connectivity”, he commented. The unique selling proposition of their tour is customization based on personal preferences of guests, local chefs and women as food guides, Multiple types of food tours available ranging from 2 to 3h to multiple days and focus on individual travellers and small groups.

Few challenges faced by Delhi culinary tours, as explained by him are “The old food joints are still a bit resistant to change their ways of cooking and presentation [...] and a lot of effort is required to make them follow simple food safety guidelines. Also, infrastructure and cleanliness in Old Delhi area need immediate action [...] The main road of Chandni chowk is undergoing construction since long the process is slow thus, causing inconvenience to the tourists”.

Interviewee IV mentioned, “Major challenge is mindset of people running food business in Chandni Chowk, who are old and having heritage, taste which is backed by traditions. They are obstinate to change in terms of their food representation and food preparation [...] and they are the ones carrying the real and true representation of Delhi food”.

However, this is not the case with all the vendors. He elucidates, “Food is the most important factor; hence, it should be a blend of varied local ingredients and flavors, quality and freshness of the ingredients is also very important [...] Personalization is the most important factor in hospitality industry and tour guide should pay heed to special requests so that the customer feels he is important and needed”.

They are also indulged in philanthropic activities in the field of youth empowerment. “Now a days, tourists are self-driven [...] and want to indulge in such activities, it gives them enhanced satisfaction to be associated with such an activity or organization”.

Interviewee V had a strong viewpoint on the locations which are being chosen by the food tours of Delhi is of prime importance as some of the joints being chosen are not the true representatives of the Delhi culture. “Instead of having a myopic approach to benefit a business/culture, a holistic approach should be followed so that the country as a whole is benefitted [...] Customization with respect to the taste preferences of culinary tourists is however important”, he stated.

He adds, “A good guide with passion of food will know, what will a tourist like when he is coming from a particular country [...] as he will have the knowledge about a country’s cuisines, ingredients and cooking styles [...] the guides should be equipped with appropriate knowledge and strength to take care of any complications”. The USP of the tour is 50% of the profit goes to an NGO Learning by local one of the sister organization which help people develop life skills and professional skills.

Interviewee VI also expressed his focus on the food quality and hygiene and cleanliness to be a supreme factor while going for a food tour. He mentions, “Food ingredients should be fresh [...] [...] A lot of care should be taken while preparing cuisines as these cuisines are face of Indian culinary arts”.

As per him, customer experience also holds quite importance as he repeatedly mentions, “Customer experiences is driven by customization, delivering sensory experiences to the customers [...] A culinary tourist in Chandni Chowk smells the aromas of varied food and spices, he witnesses lots of hustle bustle, energy and colors while tasting the incredible Indian dishes”.

Their food tour lay stress on tour guide, his knowledge about the industry, Indian history and also, the language skills part.

Customer perspective

The following reflect the customer experiences while undergoing a food tour in Delhi. The final themes that emerged from the literature, industry experts' interviews and customer feedback are shown in Table 4. Based on these themes, it can be inferred that international tourists are satisfied with food tours being run in Delhi still there are areas which needs to be addressed and improved to deliver superior experience.

Food. "Food is not just eating energy. It's an experience", a quote by Guy Fieri holds quite true. Food offered by Delhi is no less, it offers various cuisines which are quite interesting, aromatic and appetizing.

Quality. Food quality is paramount factor when it comes to gastronomy tours. High quality food should be presented to tourists and freshness of the all the ingredients should be ensured. Customers described food walks of Delhi as "quality of food and vendors was given utmost importance", "undoubtedly quality food", "quality products", "excellent quality food" authenticity.

When a tourist is travelling for gastronomic purposes, he seeks local and authentic food experiences. Tourists generally visit a country via adapted versions of the cuisines, thus, when a tourist visits a country he wishes to taste, see the real food. Customer expressions such as "having masala tea at a local tea corner", "authentic Indian food made our day", "Local food was incredible butter chicken, samosas, Goat Shish, Lassis, Kulfi", "experiencing real local culture", "real Indian feast" elucidate the idea better.

Variation in food menu. Besides authenticity, the food should be varied and different in terms of textures, smell, spices. Delhi food tours food was best described as "street food variation", "fantastic kaleidoscope of food choices", "Cuisines were balanced in terms of gravies, snacks, main course", "innumerable food discoveries", "different combinations of the same food activate different taste centers on the palate". The idea of dishes being served with postcard description was quite a hit. Few items which were adored by the international tourists included Chhole bhaturey (Chickpea with deep fried poppable puffed bread), Lassi (Buttermilk), samosa(fried or baked pastry with a savoury filling, such as spiced potatoes, onions, peas and meats), butter chicken, goat shish (Skewered kebabs), sorbets, jalebis, nagori poori aaloo halwa (Deep fried bread with potato gravy and semolina dessert), naan khatai (short bread biscuits), rice pudding, mutton, masala chai(masala tea), paranthas, kulfis, fruit sandwich, bread pakora, aaloo chaat, yellow peas with kulcha, chickpea with kachori (spicy), stuffed Kulfi -Mango and pomegranate, chickpea with rice and spinach, rasgulla dumplings (a syrupy dessert) kathi roll – skewers of soya.

Quantity of food. Quantity is also a significant factor while going in for a food walk as lesser portions result in an "incomplete food tour" and discontented feeling. Posts such as "there was unlimited food", ample number of dishes", "By the end of the tour, we were quite full", "I hope we had left the hotel without having breakfast", "quantity was plentiful", "Sampling diverse range of foods and we ended up being full" and substantiate the fact that the food tours in Delhi do not compromise on food quantity.

Hygiene and cleanliness. Decent standards of personal hygiene should be maintained by food joints and restaurants; tour managers must pay adequate attention to it. A traveler visits a destination for several days, mostly with planned itineraries, falling sick on a travel ruins the whole tour. While travellers mentioned the food joints they had food were hygienic, "they did not encounter stomach upset or any kind of illness "we believed we were in safe hands", "food safety was the main concern of the tour leaders" "no need to worry about hygiene", "Hygiene was good" shows how tours agencies in Delhi are cautious about cleanliness.

Tour guide. Training and certifications. Training and certifications ought to be given due attention as these culinary managers carry a national reputation with them and they are the face of Indian culinary industry. Comments such as "quite professional and undertaken

training”, “Certified professional lead the tour” report the fact that most of the culinary organization managers’ are trained and certified professionals.

Professional. To deliver a seamless customer experience, it is a prerequisite to be a professional, food tours being no exception. Tour services ought to be professional in terms of punctuality, customer’s requests, cancellation and refund policies. managers should take seriously. Some attributes used for guide in customer feedback included “dedicated”, ‘punctual”, “courteous”, “quite professional”. A tour guide must be nice, amiable, empathetic and pay heed to all requests made to him during the trip. A great guide while being chatty should discover the personality and moods of the fellow group and hence, alter the conversations and the tasting tour accordingly. Tourists comments included “he was responsive to every request”, “lighthearted”, “quite empathetic”, ‘pleasing personality”, “absolutely charming”, “bright & engaging”, “[. . .] was a diamond guy”, “It was a privilege to walk with such a guide”.

Storyteller. A traveler arrives in a destination full of wonder and excitement, it depends on the guide how can he channelize the energy and make the tourist even more excited telling him about the history, culture, traditions behind the food. Reviews of Delhi food walks included phrases such as” engaging”, “quite a conversationalist”, “a storyteller”, history through the lens of food”, “described little history of each place”, “fascinating history lessons”.

Informative. Many food tours are run by chefs, restaurateurs, cooking show presenters, therefore, they carry a great deal for passion of food and deep understanding about the subject food. Such tour guides carry deep knowledge which they are not reluctant to transfer among the tourists. Their skill and expertise are showcased by the information they disseminate about the ingredients and spices. Tourists revealed, “the guide knew how different combinations of the same food would activate different taste centers on the palate”, “remarkable guide-witty and informative”, “his passion for Delhi and passion for food was great”, ‘in depth knowledge of cuisines”, “quite insightful” to appreciate the guide.

Language skills. Language skills are the elementary component of a good food tour. When an international tourist visits a place with an objective to experience local food in an authentic manner, communication becomes all the more important to make him comprehend the local essence of the food and reasons behind it. Therefore, language skills of the guide become quite relevant. “Spoke excellent English”, “Perfect English”, “English was fluent”, “Language skills were great”, “Our guide spoke better English than us” from a United Kingdom Tourist explains there are not much language related issues in Delhi gastronomic tours lately. However, few old reviews of 2018 from tourists mention language issues and described, “Driver could not speak English”, “his English was hard to understand”, referring to a tour guide implying this issue has been resolved over the years.

Customization. Customization has become the need of the hour in any business with special focus on service industry. Customization in food walks is crucial as it has a lot to do with the taste buds and health of the traveler.

Food preferences. Tourist preference whether he is a vegetarian, non-vegetarian or a vegan need to be considered.

Food allergies. Food allergies, such as dairy allergy, gluten allergy etc., are common among people these days and tour agencies must ensure the tourist with a specific allergy does not taste that cuisine containing the same ingredient.

Tourists described the tour as “accommodating”, “flexible”, “Customizable”, “tailored for the group”. In case some travellers got late, tour guide ensured he enjoyed all the delicacies even it took a little extra time and effort to re-do a part of tour. Pick up and drop facilities are made available on request too.

Locations of food tastings. Locations of Delhi food tours emphasize on the taste, hygiene and the history and pay least attention to backgrounds or profitability to any vendor. There is no favouritism done on the basis of religion, culture or profit but the true window of Delhi heritage is being showcased. Comments from travellers mentioned “Hole in the wall places”, “Bustling street”, “crazy vibrant place”, “crowded & Chaotic”, “Raw Street life”, “Fresh flower markets were lovely”, “Aromatic spice market”, “Gurudwara and community kitchen was a wonderful experience”, “It was a real deal and not just the touristy flow”. Also, while food items reflect how best food of all possible communities of Delhi have been included in the food tours.

Cultural policy ought to play an important role during selection process of the food, cuisines and the tour destinations so as they are the best representation of the community and no businesses are favoured by the private companies or tour operators for self-interest.

Infrastructure and facilities. Modes of travel and infrastructure. Food walks are conducted in restaurants as well as congested lanes. A well-developed infrastructure helps in carving out a good food tour which can be carried out in a smooth manner. For example- In case of street food offering variety of modes of travel is crucial. The roads as well as the overall infrastructure of the place where food tours are being conducted ought to be appropriate so that the customer does not undergo any inconvenience. Customers enjoyed by foot, by electric Tuk Tuk, by taxis and by rickshaws. What mode of transport is chosen to conduct food tour and whether customer satisfaction was attained via the same or not is essential. Customers mentioned “all modes of travel were utilized”, “walking was not strenuous”, “Tuk tuk and the bicycle rickshaw was great”, “exploring Delhi by foot and by e-Rickshaws was amazing in itself”

Goody bags comprising packaged water bottles, hand sanitizers, anti-bacterial wipes were admired by everyone. “host came prepared with water, wipes, etc.”, “Tour included goody bags with wipes and sanitizers which were quite useful”, “Complimentary wet wipes and hand sanitizers”.

Philanthropic activities. Customers have a bent towards altruistic practices and giving back to the society. It gives a customer pride when he indirectly contributes to the society. “Delhi by Locals” claim to donate 50% of their profit towards youth empowerment. Other food walks also are indulged in various activities such as donating gloves, caps to food vendors which makes a tourist happy and gives pride to be associated with such a tour. Feedbacks mentioned “We are happy to promote slum kid’s education”, “Tour guide cared a lot about India and was involved with non- profit organizations”.

Price of the tour. Price of the tour is an important factor which comes into picture while deciding for a food tour. Pricing of the tour should be designed such that it may occur to the tourist that his taste buds were fully satiated after the tour and he should feel the tour was worthy and the pricing was value based. TripAdvisor witnessed some comments such as “The tour was pricey”, “Overpriced at first but then felt it was worth it” but prevailing opinion was of the tours was “worth the time & money”, “absolutely worth”, “would definitely do this again”.

Digital presence. Digital platforms and Internet behold the power of making a tourist choose their travel destination and Social Media and websites such as TripAdvisor have a huge amount of UGC which plays a deciding role in whether to undertake such tours while visiting a destination. Hence, a well-positioned and positive digital presence plays an important role.

Online reputation management. The customers give their constant feedback and write about griefs and discontentment to voice their opinions; therefore, it is significant to maintain digital reputation and online credibility. It was observed all the 3 food tours have reverted on each of the customer reviews either with gratification mail or an apology mail and tried to stipulate all cases of customer dissatisfaction.

Pre and post communication are also critical factors wherein customer feels esteemed and empowered. Reviews such as “Pre tour communication was prompt and informative”, “emails were promptly exchanged” connote due importance is paid to communication.

Brand perception of Indian culinary industry. The customer reviews of international tourist cite their preconceived notions and apprehensions about Indian food prevailing internationally which later is mentioned to be incorrect in their customer reviews. Regarding spiciness of Indian food, there were assumptions such as “some were apprehensive about overly spicy food”, “India is known for its spicy food”. Also, tourist stated “Well not that spicy but tasty”.

The notion regarding Indian food being just about curries was also falsified by many tourists as they cite “Now we know there is more to Indian food than curries, samosas and poppadums!”, “there was much more than savoury curries”, though most of the culinary tourists loved the curry and mention “the magic curry will always be remembered”, “wonderful curries”.

The third perception about which one of the tour managers also discussed was the phrase “Delhi Belly” which refers to the traveller’s diarrhoea or traveller’s stomach upset, heartburn, indigestion etc. which usually occurs on eating street food. Reviews such as “tried food in locations that had been thoroughly vetted for hygiene and safety for foreign tummies”, “All the eating places visited are vetted for hygiene standards, no dodgy tummies at all”, “I have always avoided street food like the plague in most parts of the world, due to hygiene concerns” reflect an underlying assumption of getting sick after eating street food or undertaking culinary tours. Many culinary tourists mention “we never worried about hygiene or getting sick “hygiene was outstanding at all visited establishments” imply that such notions do not hold true in case of Indian culinary tours.

It is of utmost priority to shed these stereotypes and deliver consistent remarkable culinary tours. Attempts must be made in digitally so that the international brand perception of Indian food improves and busts all the myths.

Conclusion and recommendations

There is a considerable gap between potential of Delhi as a gastronomic hub and what Delhi as a gastronomic hub is currently delivering. The need for a larger customer base for Delhi culinary tourism is quite apparent. Thematic analysis identified some vital issues resulting into negative customer experiences whilst most reviews reflect the satisfaction from the tour. A tourist comprehends about heritage of a destination through experience and can develop marketing strategies and tourism products around tourist’s satisfaction ([Hendijani, 2016](#)).

International tourists have a lack of perception and have certain stereotypes about Delhi cuisines. The key approach to increase gastronomic tourism in India is improvement in terms of infrastructure and cleanliness. However, most tourists reported that they did not encounter any Delhi belly, but this Indian food image needs a quick and enduring transition which can be done via altering the perception of the consumers via some rebranding strategies ([Combe et al., 2003](#)). Mediums such as Blogs, Social Media can prove favourable for Indian culinary industry. The electronic word of mouth lessens the cost of new customer acquisition, has a greater reach and boost tourists’ trust via brand advocacy.

The transformation must be made in the mindsets of business owners of old food establishments which carry legacy, delectable taste in their food. They need to make changes in their ways of cooking and serving and following simple food safety guidelines so that they do not leave any doubts in tourists’ minds. Government in coalition with local culinary associations should ensure this by making appropriate awareness. Attention must be paid to the location of food tastings as the chosen ones ought to be the true

representation of Delhi culture and Delhi food. Government or culinary associations can arrange great food festivals on an international scale events such as Pizzafest in Italy, Oktoberfest in Germany, dumpling fest in Hong Kong and should promote it on digital Media internationally.

The findings of this study allude that the tour operator should be a professional with all certifications and qualities such as informative, accommodating, personable and imbibe the great art of storytelling. Also, the findings indicated customization is the key for a positive customer experience, food tours being no exception. Tour operators need to understand the customers first, their food choices, food allergies and hence should personalize the food tours accordingly. Promoting and preserving national cuisines serves great value in promoting culinary tourism of a nation as many cuisines die out over the time because of the spread of global cuisines and increasing standardization of the recipes.

Although this study corroborates valuable academic findings and practical insights, it has few limitations that can be further investigated in the future. A quantitative study can be conducted to provide deeper insights into the factors of a culinary tour resulting in positive customer experience. Secondly, this study focuses on food tours which are one of the methods of culinary tourism, another elaborate study can be conducted incorporating other methods of culinary tourism such as cooking classes, festivals and events etc. of Delhi and find the customer experiences and challenges in those practices.

Implications of the study

The paper aims to increase gastronomic tourism competitiveness of the city by helping the individual providers such as culinary tour agencies, food joints, restaurants to incorporate essential required elements into their experiences. By employing findings of the study, to culinary organizations, tourism marketers and all other stakeholders would be better able to position themselves better and utilize their tourism resources in best optimized manner. Also, the issues faced by the industry and the unsatisfied customer feedbacks brings up the areas of improvement where Delhi lacks as a culinary destination. Marketing the cuisines in the right manner and upgrading infrastructure, facilities and giving precedence to hygiene can lead to a positive word of mouth attracting more culinary tourists. Likewise, Restaurants, travel agencies and other involved organizations should pay heed to professionalism and make strong digital presence. The research also enriched the literature about international tourists' gastronomic experiences and their overall level of satisfaction with food tours being conducted in Delhi.

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